

The Great Wooden Horse

The windswept shores of Troy stretch along a bright Aegean sea, where wooden ships with painted eyes lie beached on the long sand and a great city of honey-coloured walls stands proud on the hill above. For a long while two camps, the weary seafarers on the beach and the proud city behind its gates, have been caught in a tired old quarrel that neither truly wants. Across the wine-dark sea lies the long road home, full of wonders: a loyal old hound, a keeper of the winds, and lonely sea-singers on the rocks. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is brave, loyal, and full of ideas. The grandest deeds are done not with spears but with a good idea and a kind heart, and the oldest quarrels often end with a single brave act of friendship.

The answers are here. This part is for the grown-up, not for the child.

Show the matching picture in the Atlas as you reach each place.



Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.

Before you begin

For a long, long time the two camps on the windswept shores of Troy have been cross with each other. The seafarers live in tents and wooden ships along the beach. The proud city sits up on the hill behind great honey-coloured walls, with its gates shut tight. Nobody quite remembers how the quarrel began. The truth is, everyone is rather tired of it, and both camps secretly wish it would just stop.

Odysseus the Bright calls you to him. He has a curly beard and a kind, twinkly smile, and in his hands he holds a tiny wooden horse. "I have a good idea," he says. "Let us build a great wooden horse, as big as a house. But we will not fill it with soldiers. We will fill it with gifts and music and friendship, and roll it to the gates as a happy surprise. That is how we end the quarrel."

He gives you three gifts: a basket of honey and figs, Penelope's thread, and a conch horn. Then he smiles. "On these shores we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being brave, loyal to a friend, and full of ideas."



What is your hero name? Will you carry Imagination, Courage, or Loyalty?

Stop 1 Building the Horse

On the beach lie heaps of smooth wooden planks. The horse must be built tall and strong, so it stands up without wobbling, with a little door in its side.

The builders scratch their heads. How many planks for each leg? How do you fit the curved pieces so they balance? Penelope's thread can measure each piece, and careful counting will tell you how many you need.



How could you build it so it stands up straight? Could you measure with the thread? Could you count the planks together? Try something and see.

When you fit the pieces and balance them just right, the great wooden horse rises up on its wheels, tall and proud and steady. Everyone cheers.

Stop 2 Filling It with Friendship

Now the horse is built, and its little door stands open. What should you put inside? Not soldiers, never soldiers. The whole idea is a kind surprise.

You look at all the lovely things on the beach: the basket of figs, garlands of bright flowers, and a little drum for happy music.



What kind things would make the best surprise? Which gifts say "let us be friends"? Choose together. There is no wrong answer here.

When you tuck the figs, the flowers, and the little drum inside, the horse feels warm and welcoming, like a present waiting to be opened. It is the friendliest horse anyone has ever seen.

Stop 3 The Surprise at the Gates

Slowly, slowly, you roll the great horse up the hill to the city gates. The folk on the walls peer down. They look wary and weary. The gates stay shut. For a moment, your heart thumps.

But this is not a fight. It is a gift. You only need to show them it is kind.



What could you do to show them you come as friends? You have the conch horn to sound a warm hello. You could open the horse's door and share the figs. What do you try?

When you sound the conch horn and open the door, out tumble figs and flowers and a merry drumbeat. The watchful folk gasp, then laugh, then beam. Slowly, the great gates creak open at last.

The Long Quarrel Ends

The city folk come down from their walls, and the seafarers come up from the beach, and they meet in the middle, a little shy. Then someone shares a fig. Someone beats the little drum. Someone laughs, and then everyone laughs.

The two camps spread out a great feast together, side by side, as if the quarrel had never been. Out on the calm water, Thetis the Sea-Mother lifts her head from the waves and smiles. You did it together. You were brave, you were loyal, and you were full of ideas, and the oldest quarrel of all has ended with a kind surprise. Well done, heroes of Troy.

The Great Wooden Horse: Rules for the Grown-Up

The Guide for the Grown-Up explains how the game works; read it once and you are set. This page holds only what is special about this story. A failed roll is never a defeat; nobody loses. This is a gentle tale with no battle in it at all: the two old camps are simply weary of quarrelling, and the heroes win by ending the quarrel with a kind surprise.

Setting up

- Print the map. Each player puts a small figure on the Start, the Ship Camp on the beach.
- This world has no magic. Instead each hero leans on one of three qualities: **Imagination** (dreaming up ideas), **Courage** (a steady heart), or **Loyalty** (keeping faith with a friend). On the hero sheet, where it says magic, let each child write the quality they like best. Two different qualities work best together.
- Give each player five energy stars (five small tokens or bricks). They are spent and refilled during play.
- Set out three props if you can: a ball of string for Penelope's thread, a few small treats or tokens for the basket of honey and figs, and any shell or cup for the conch horn. Anything can be anything.
- Keep your dice and the dice-band table from the back of the kit beside you.

The Twist of Fate

Once at each place the players may roll for a twist; read the matching line. The Guide explains how it works.

Roll	Twist of Fate
1	Odysseus the Bright gives you one free hint.
2	You catch your second wind, and take back one energy star.
3	A fair wind, and the next challenge is Easy.
4	Argos the Faithful Hound trots up and wags his tail. All is well.
5	A basket of figs for luck: keep one roll to use again later.
6	A warm sea breeze, and for a moment everyone feels brave.

How it ends

The wary city at the gates is the "obstacle", but there is no villain here at all, and not one soldier hides inside the horse. The proud city is simply tired of an old quarrel, just as the seafarers are. The tale is won not by beating anyone but by surprising the weary city with friendship: a warm note on the conch horn, an open door, and a shared basket of figs. Let the kindness land; it is the whole point. See the puzzles page for the three challenges and their solutions.

The Great Wooden Horse: Puzzles and Solutions

For your eyes, not the children's. Each stop lists its band, what the players need to work out, the intended solution, and a gentle fallback so a stuck child always moves forward. More than one good idea should work; reward imagination and kindness over the "right" answer.

Stop 1: Building the Horse (Normal)

The challenge. The great wooden horse must be built tall, strong, and steady on its wheels, with a little door in its side. The players help the carpenters work out how the wooden pieces fit and balance, and how many planks the build will need.

Intended solution. This is a moment of Imagination, Logic, and a little Spatial thinking and Maths. The bright move is to use **Penelope's thread** to measure a piece before it is cut, and to count the planks together so each leg matches and the body balances. Sorting the pieces by shape, or laying out a simple plan before building, works just as well. Settling on any sensible, balanced plan passes the stop.

Fallback. If the children are unsure, have a friendly carpenter hold up two planks and ask, "Which of these is longer, do you think?", or let them spend an energy star to "measure twice and cut once". Counting out loud together always gets there. Any steady plan raises the horse and tops up an energy star.

Make it simpler. For a very young builder, just stack four wooden blocks for the legs and one on top for the body, and cheer the little horse standing up.

Stop 2: Filling It with Friendship (Easy)

The challenge. The horse is built and its door stands open. The players choose what to put inside. The whole idea is a kind surprise, so the answer is never soldiers and never anything frightening, only friendly things.

Intended solution. This is a gentle Social-emotional and Logic moment. Any warm, welcoming choice works: the **basket of honey and figs** to share, garlands of bright **flowers**, and a **little drum** for happy music. Ask the children which gifts say "let us be friends", and let them explain why. Naming any kind gift, and saying why it is kind, passes the stop.

Fallback. If a child suggests something fierce, gently wonder aloud together, "How would the city folk feel if they opened the door and found that? What would make them smile instead?" Steer warmly towards the figs, the flowers, and the drum. Choosing any kind thing is a full success and tops up an energy star.

Make it simpler. Ask a little one to pick just one nice thing from the room, a soft toy or a snack, and pop it inside the horse to share.

Stop 3: The Surprise at the Gates (Normal)

The challenge. The heroes roll the horse up to the city gates, which stay shut. The watchful folk on the walls look wary and weary. The players may feel this is a standoff. It is not. It is a gift waiting to be opened.

Intended solution. This is a moment of Courage and Social-emotional warmth. The city is not an enemy, only tired and unsure. Any genuine, friendly gesture works: sounding the **conch horn** as a warm hello, opening the horse's door, sharing the **figs**, calling up a kind word, or beating the little drum. When the surprise of friendship lands, the great gates swing open. Showing the city any clear sign of friendship passes the stop.

Fallback. If the children freeze, or imagine the gates will never open, have a single curious child appear at the top of the wall and call down, "Is that... for us?" The smallest kindness, a

wave, a fig held up, a soft note on the horn, melts the wariness and the gates begin to open.

Make it simpler. Let a little one simply wave and call out "hello, friends!" to the city, and that warm greeting swings the gates wide.

The ending

There is no battle and no loser, and there never was a soldier in the horse. When the surprise of friendship works, the proud city opens its gates, the two camps spread a feast together on the hillside, and **Thetis the Sea-Mother** smiles from the calm water. The heroes have won the only way anyone wins here, by being brave, loyal to a friend, and full of ideas.

Wander and Tales

Tale Book

<https://github.com/agigante80/wander-and-tales>

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Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.